

Sisterhood and Shadows: Women Who Definitely Tried to Haunt Your Dreams

(And an unfortunate reading of subpar writing for you)

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Introduction to Gender Studies

Introduction

We'll discuss not one, not two, but three whole movies directed by women(that was just dramatic effect. We will be discussing two movies.) Painstakingly I have watched- for the sake of 20 marks- the wonderful, captivating and absolutely relatable movies "Little Women" directed by Greta Gerwig(Yay, Barbie!) and "Bulbbul" by Anvita Dutt(It rained when I watched two movies back-to-back, just saying. This was God picking his weakest soldier to do the toughest task).

A classic that was equal parts heartwarming and like someone stuck a chainsaw in my eyes(this is good), "Little Women" directed by the talented Greta Gerwig offers a very fast moving tale for us to behold. She picked up a unique vision and made the movie stand out like never before(yes, there was a before- movies, cartoons, series, the whole lot). Her vision gave the movie a modern spirit and a look that would make me and my grandmother cry together.

On the other hand, we also discuss the fully deranged and absolutely terrifying story "Bulbbul" directed by the also talented(and very, *very* scary) Anvita Dutt. She offered us stunning visuals, beautiful costuming and an allure to the story that made us walk into a period piece but made us walk out with *genuine* fear for our lives.

While these films might seem worlds apart on the surface, they both offer insightful perspectives on women's experiences. Through the March sisters' unwavering bond and Bulbbul's chilling quest for justice, we'll explore themes of female agency, societal constraints, and the unexpected ways sisterhood can manifest. So, grab your metaphorical popcorn (and maybe a nightlight for Bulbbul), and let us delve into the power of female filmmakers to weave tales that are both heartwarming and haunting.

Bulbbul

19th Century Bengal. A child bride is seen asking her elders "Why must I wear the toe ring?"

She is answered with “There is a nerve here. If I do not press it, girls tend to fly away.” This is the beginning of Bulbbul’s life as a slave in action, and the story of how she later learns to fly.

In Bulbbul, a child bride finds solace only in her brother-in-law, Satya. Years later, her cruel husband Indranil destroys her happiness and leaves her for dead. A horrific assault by her brother-in-law, Mahendra triggers a supernatural transformation, granting Bulbbul chilling power. As mysterious deaths plague the village, Satya returns to find Bulbbul a vengeful spirit punishing those who exploit women. The film culminates in a tragic fire, revealing the depths of Bulbbul's suffering and her desperate quest for justice.

Bulbbul explores themes of patriarchal violence, revenge, and the struggle for power. The film depicts a web of complex relationships. Bulbbul's marriage to Indranil is one of exploitation, while her bond with Satya is one of stolen innocence. Jealousy festers between Bulbbul and her sister-in-law Binodini, leading to an unintended consequence. Mahendra's mental state is used to justify his abuse, while Bulbbul finds a fragile connection with the doctor, Sudip, who becomes her sole confidante. Director Anvita Dutt doesn't shy away from the brutality Bulbbul endures, yet also portrays the female characters with strength and subtle power. Bulbbul's story is a powerful testament to the resilience of the human spirit in the face of unimaginable suffering.

The director Anvita Dutt even showed us that she is unafraid of showing us the gory side of such abuse and many avenues to make it clear, including the very striking visual aspects of the movie. She showcases the female characters with great care and very thinly veiled power and strength, which was very beautiful to watch.

Little Women

Little Women revisits the March sisters – Jo, Meg, Beth, and Amy – as they navigate life and love in 1800s Massachusetts. Each sister chases a dream: Jo, a fiery writer defying gender norms; Meg, yearning for a loving marriage; Beth, finding solace in music; and Amy, seeking artistic refinement.

The film seamlessly blends their present struggles with cherished memories, showcasing their unwavering bond. Jo battles a male-dominated publishing world, while Meg grapples with societal expectations. Beth's illness brings a shadow, and Amy confronts the complexities of love and money.

Despite these challenges, the sisters find strength and support in each other. They challenge societal limitations, offering encouragement in a world that tries to define them. Their paths may not be linear, but they ultimately achieve their dreams, with some compromises. "Little Women" celebrates the power of family, the complexities of love, and the human spirit's resilience.

The film explores themes of family, following your dreams, and a subtle form of feminism in a post-war world. The large, interconnected cast showcases the strength of their bond. We see them collaborate in plays and eventually run a school together, overcoming disagreements through unwavering love.

Laurie, a close friend, falls for Jo but is later rejected. He then finds love with Amy, while remaining close to the entire family. Marmee, their stern yet loving mother, plays a crucial role. We see her learn patience and become the caring woman she is today. The daughters hold no resentment, only love. The film beautifully captures Jo's words to Meg on her wedding day: "You will be bored of him in two years, and we will be interesting forever."

Gerwig approaches this through her non linear narrative, something we have not seen in prior adaptations of the movie. She also brings focus to Jo's story as a writer and we see her a lot more. The movie weaves in themes of female agency and self-determination.

Representation of Families

Bulbbul

Bulbbul's young marriage into Indranil's family exemplifies a patriarchal society. Sent away (virilocality), she finds no support. Indranil embodies the "eldest-son-first" hierarchy, controlling every aspect of life. Bulbbul, seen as a child-bearing vessel, endures constant abuse from male family members. Mahendra's cruelty is excused due to illness, highlighting the lack of accountability. Only Satya challenges this order, leaving the family in the film's climax. Despite attempts to appear otherwise, their desperation to maintain control exposes the film's rigidly patriarchal core.

Little Women

In "Little Women," family is a powerful force. The March sisters, facing poverty and societal limitations, rely on their unwavering bond. They support and encourage each other's dreams: Jo finds strength in her sisters' belief in her writing. Beth's illness strengthens their bond, highlighting the power of family love in adversity.

The film also redefines family structure. Marmee, the strong mother figure, leads the family in their father's absence. The sisters depend on each other emotionally and financially, creating a unique dynamic that challenges the traditional nuclear family. Ultimately, "Little Women" celebrates chosen family. Love and support within this unit allows the sisters to overcome hardships and achieve personal fulfillment. We even see the sisters stepping into different family roles. While Beth mirrors Marmee's nurturing nature, Jo takes on traits of their strong father figure.

Role of Family Dynamics in Character Experience and Identity

Bulbbul

Bulbbul's story is one of resilience and transformation. Trapped in a family that abuses her, she endures cruelty from every member. Yet, she doesn't break. Instead, she navigates the power dynamics within the family, learning to manipulate them for her own survival. This constant discrimination, based on her age, gender, and kindness, fuels her rage. The abuse ultimately leads to a supernatural awakening, turning her into a vengeful spirit seeking justice not just for herself, but for every wronged woman.

Satya, Bulbbul's childhood friend and brother-in-law, initially reflects traditional family values. He controls Bulbbul's interactions and subtly belittles women while investigating the murders. However, as the film progresses, he witnesses the devastating impact of the family's actions. He comes to understand the abuse Bulbbul faced and the flaws within the system. This realization leads him to break free from the family structure, taking the first step towards becoming a better person.

Little Women

Jo: Rebelling against domesticity, Jo fights gender bias in the literary world. Family support fuels her fiery spirit, but societal pressure forces her to compromise her writing dreams.

Meg: She is caught between love and financial security, Meg navigates societal pressure to marry well. Though she is advised against it, Meg ultimately prioritizes her own happiness which comes with its own difficulties.

Beth: Beth's artistic pursuits face fewer limitations, but family burdens due to poverty restrict her opportunities. An underestimated and unfairly treated character, whose unfortunate purpose was to bring the family back together after her death.

Amy: Aspiring to social advancement, Amy grapples with societal expectations for refinement. Her thoughts are reinforced by her Aunt March, but Amy ultimately negotiates, marrying for love and her happiness.

Point of View

"Little Women" unfolds primarily through Jo's perspective. While glimpses of Amy and Meg's lives are shown, Jo's experience anchors the story. The film cleverly reveals this at the end, with Jo explaining choices to her editor. Yet, despite Jo's central role, the film offers a clear view of each sister's personality and how they function as a group and as individuals. Ultimately, "Little Women" celebrates resilience in a patriarchal world. It emphasizes that sisterhood, love, and perseverance are the keys to navigating a society that might not readily accept their dreams. The

film's message is one of hope: "The world may be challenging, but you can overcome its limitations and create your own path."

In stark contrast, *Bulbbul* unfolds from a distant perspective. There's no clear narrator; we don't know who's witnessing the events. We understand *Bulbbul* is the vengeful spirit, but beyond that, details remain ambiguous. Without seeing things through *Bulbbul*'s eyes, the viewer becomes a detached observer, witnessing the events within the mansion. The focus is on the oppressive nature of patriarchy. While the lines between reality and *Bulbbul*'s revenge blur, the film effectively portrays the brutality of the society. Unlike "*Little Women*," *Bulbbul* offers no solution or escape. Its message is bleak: "The world is brutal and unforgiving. Your struggle against its horrors might offer a temporary release, but the cycle continues."

Based on My Analysis

Despite their cultural differences, both *Bulbbul* (Indian) and *Little Women* (American) resonate with a common message: the struggles and limitations faced by women. *Bulbbul* blatantly exposes ingrained gender roles. Men offer no support, dictate whims, and limit *Bulbbul*'s agency. Director Anvita Dutt doesn't sugarcoat the injustices, showcasing their impact and how *Bulbbul* silently endures until forced to react. Her only control comes in managing the estate while her husband is away. Here, the film presents the problem, not a solution, highlighting the silencing and oppression women face.

Little Women, directed by Greta Gerwig, paints a different picture. The March sisters actively work against societal norms, crafting their own paths. They achieve their goals, with men as partners, not superiors. Gender roles exist, but men act as support systems, not obstacles. Gerwig emphasizes the power of sisterhood and problem-solving, suggesting a hopeful path to overcome limitations.

These contrasting viewpoints stem from cultural differences. Gerwig showcases the American spirit of female progress, highlighting the path women have taken. It's a testament to the strides American women have made. Conversely, Dutt reveals that despite India's modernization, women still grapple with the vestiges of a patriarchal past. While rights and agency have been gained, the film suggests a lingering societal burden.

Both films are undeniably shaped by their female directors. The pain, truth, and nuances on display are undeniably feminine perspectives. Men play different roles – plot devices in *Little Women* and practically invisible in *Bulbbul*, yet central to the narrative. These unique approaches connect the films through relatable struggles, bringing audiences closer despite cultural separations.

We need women in film like men need a woman at home.

I hope you'll forgive the lack of comedy outside of the introduction. It ate up my word-limit like it was a couple biscuits.